

Wilting Lotus

With defections in the ranks and the Left and Mayawati grabbing the main Opposition space, the BJP and its leadership have lost their momentum

■ By Priya Sahgal

This was not a chapter that L.K. Advani would highlight in his memoirs. But the recent vote of confidence has left the BJP looking bewildered and somewhat shaky. And with good reason. It was from the BJP that the treasury benches got its largest chunk of cross-party support. While four BJP MPs cross-voted in favour of the UPA, four others abstained. Advani called it a "tainted victory" for the UPA, but he only has his own MPs to blame for some of that taint.

Initially, it seemed as if BJP was a hesitant bystander while the Left and later Mayawati took on the role of the Opposition. Advani's speech at the opening of the trust vote was criticised as being too mild. Unfortunately, after fielding its main speaker, BJP was running out of steam until three of its members walked in with two bags of money and accused the UPA of bribery. It was a last minute attempt by the BJP to regain its lost ground as the main Opposition party. The BJP's second rung then did what it does best: shouted slogans and stormed the well of the House. To an extent, the gimmick succeeded in putting the Congress on the backfoot. Its huge margin of victory has come with a question mark on its ethics.

The BJP is, however, in no position to preach morality. In the last three years, as many as 10 of its MPs have been caught on camera in corruption scandals (*see box*). "It saddens me, I won't debate it," said Advani. But he took some solace in the fact, while that all the earlier scams involved lesser denominations, the three MPs alleged they had been promised Rs 3 crore each to cross-vote, an offer they rejected. Unfortunately, Advani's press conference a day after the trust vote, originally meant to point fingers at the UPA's tainted record, ended up highlighting BJP's own questionable past.

The timing of the defeat, coming as it does on the eve of five state elections, has sunk the morale in the party. Before this, the party was on a high after having registered a thumping victory in Karnataka and swearing in its first chief minister in the south just two months ago. The party's prime ministerial candidate Advani was criss-crossing the country, holding book releases and rallies, taking potshots at the prime minister. However, the tables have now turned. Emboldened by the new Lok Sabha arithmetic, it is now the prime minister who is targeting him. Since all the strategy meetings to topple the Government were held at Advani's residence, this crushing defeat has come as a severe blow to his personal reputation. Moreover, one of his chief troubleshooters could not even hold on to the MPs in his own state. Three of the eight BJP MPs who defected were from Ananth Kumar's home turf, Karnataka. The only defection his managers could ensure was that of rebel Congressman Kuldip Bishnoi. When the TRS chief made a call to the BJP leadership and said that he was willing to even join the NDA if it pledged support to the state of Telangana, the party leadership took its own time to respond. By the time it got it act together, K. Chandrashekhara Rao had already shifted loyalties in favour of BSP chief Mayawati.

But this is just one of the reasons why the BJP is worried. It clearly sees the rise of Mayawati as a potential threat to Advani's own prime ministerial dreams. This is something that most of the regional allies seem to have realised too as the Dalit leader—and not Advani—has become the magnet for the anti-Congress vote. "The trust vote became a Mayawati vs Manmohan battle. Where was Advani in all this?" asked a Congress

BJP clearly sees Mayawati's rise as a potential threat to L.K. Advani's own prime ministerial dreams. Regional allies are now beginning to look at the Dalit leader, and not Advani, as the magnet for the anti-Congress vote.